

WG04

World Agriculture

About 1 question a paper. The one documented repeat is Mediterranean agriculture and its five regions (RAS 2024, asked twice in that paper, once in the 'which is NOT' form). Everything else is a single one-liner or a match-the-following.

World Geography gives you only about three questions in the whole paper, and agriculture is one of the two places RPSC reliably digs into. Nothing here is analytical. It is types of farming matched to regions, and crops matched to leading producers. Learn it as pairs.

World Agriculture

Subsistence

- Shifting (Jhum, Milpa, Ladang)
- Nomadic herding (Bedouin, Masai)
- Intensive subsistence (monsoon Asia)

Collective / co-op

- Kolkhoz
- Sovkhoz
- Denmark

Commercial

- Extensive grain (Prairie, Pampas, Steppe)
- Mixed farming
- Dairy
- Plantation
- Market gardening

Crops & producers

- Rice/wheat - China
- Maize - USA
- Coffee & sugarcane - Brazil
- Cocoa - Cote d'Ivoire
- Palm oil - Indonesia

Mediterranean

- Med. basin
- California
- Central Chile
- SW Cape
- SW Australia

Fisheries

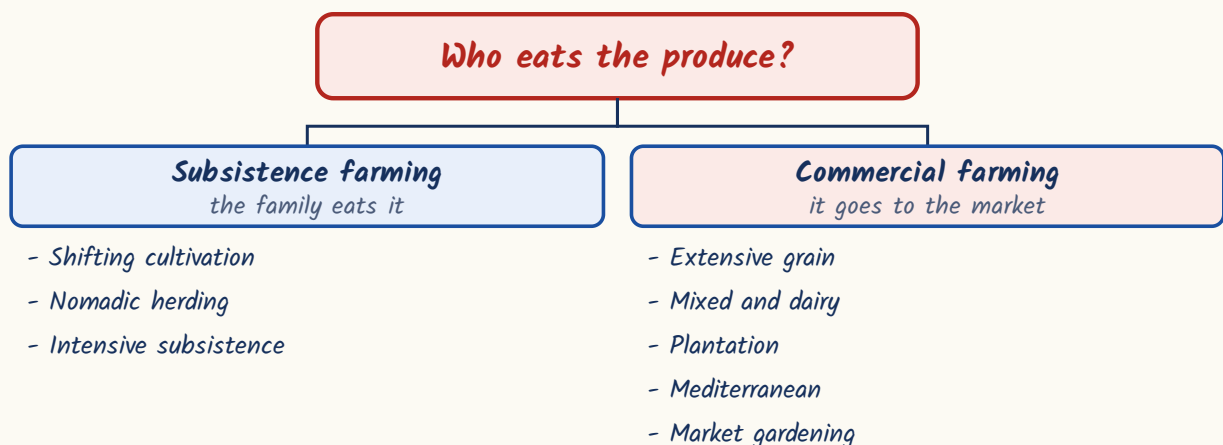
- NW Pacific
- Grand Banks
- Dogger Bank
- Peru upwelling

What 'type of agriculture' means - the classification RPSC tests

Agriculture is classified by one simple question: who eats the produce? If the farmer and his family eat most of it, that is subsistence farming. If it goes to the market, that is commercial farming. Everything else - farm size, labour, machinery, yield - follows from that one split. RPSC never asks you to argue this. It asks you to place a farming type in a region, or a region in a farming type.

- Subsistence: shifting cultivation, nomadic herding, intensive subsistence (wet paddy).
- Commercial: extensive grain, mixed farming, dairy, plantation, Mediterranean, market gardening.
- State-controlled: collective farming (Kolkhoz) and co-operative farming (Denmark).
- Yield per hectare and output per worker are two different things - keep them separate.
- Intensive subsistence has high yield per hectare but very low output per worker.
- Extensive commercial grain farming is the reverse - low yield per hectare, huge output per worker.

Agriculture classified by who eats the produce



Von Thunen's isolated-state model, 1826 - rings outward from the market



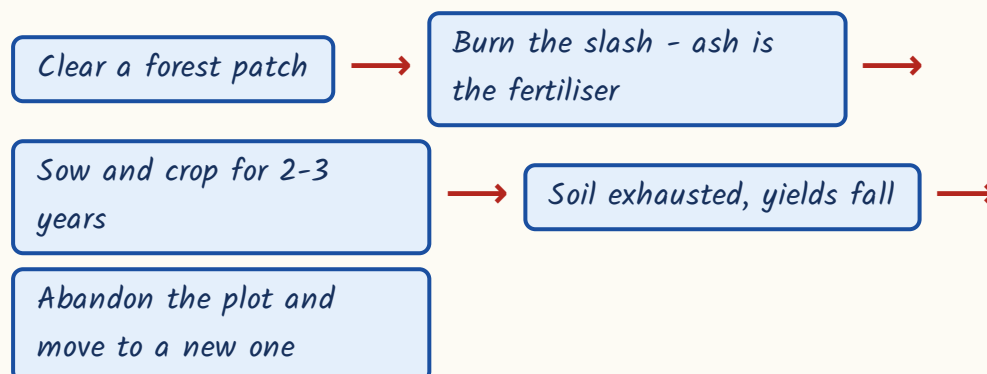
YAAD RAKHO

Von Thunen's logic in one line: the more perishable and the heavier the produce, the closer it must sit to the city. Milk and vegetables first, cattle last.

Subsistence farming - shifting, nomadic, intensive

Shifting cultivation is the oldest of the three. You clear a patch of forest, burn it, sow on the ash, take two or three crops until the soil is exhausted, then abandon the plot and move on. It survives in tropical forests. The examinable part is not the method - it is the long list of local names, which comes as a match-the-following.

The shifting cultivation cycle



Shifting cultivation - local names

Local name	Where
Jhum	North-east India

Local name	Where
Milpa	Mexico and Central America
Ladang	Indonesia and Malaysia
Chena	Sri Lanka
Roca	Brazil
Ray	Vietnam
Taungya	Myanmar
Conuco	Venezuela
Masole	Congo
Humah	Java

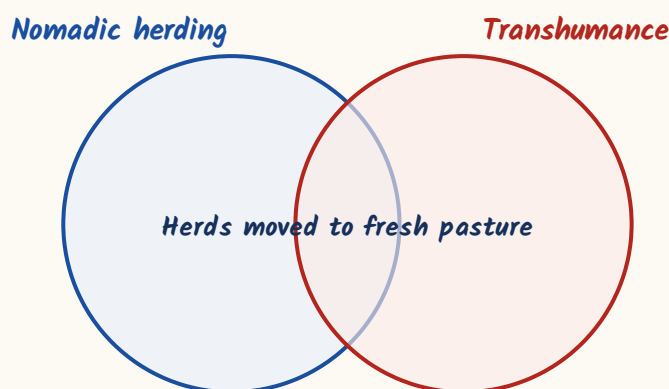
Nomadic herders - community to region and animal

Community	Region	Chief animal
Bedouin	Arabia and the Sahara	Camel
Masai	East Africa	Cattle
Lapps (Sami)	European tundra	Reindeer
Chukchi	Siberian tundra	Reindeer
Kirghiz and Kazakh	Central Asian steppe	Horse, sheep
Fulani	West Africa	Cattle

- Intensive subsistence farming = monsoon Asia, wet paddy dominant.
- Holdings are tiny, the family supplies the labour, machinery is minimal.
- Yield per hectare is high because of heavy manuring and multiple cropping.
- Output per worker stays very low - too many hands on too little land.

TRAP

Do not confuse nomadic herding with transhumance. Nomadic herders have no permanent home and wander the arid lands. Transhumance is the seasonal up-and-down movement between highland summer pasture and lowland winter pasture - the Gujjars and Bakarwals of the western Himalayas do this, and they do have fixed settlements.

Nomadic herding and transhumance

home and wander the arid lands; transhumants keep fixed settlements and move between highland summer

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: the United Nations has designated 2026 the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists, on a resolution led by Mongolia and with the FAO as the lead agency. It is the year of the herders in this section - Bedouin, Masai, Lapps, Fulani - so pair the designation with nomadic herding and with transhumance. Note that 2026 carries two FAO-linked designations at once, this one and the International Year of the Woman Farmer.

Commercial farming - grain, dairy, plantation, market gardening

Commercial farming means growing for sale. In the temperate grasslands it takes the extensive form - enormous farms, heavy machinery, wheat and cattle. In the tropics it takes the plantation form - one cash crop, a large estate, hired labour. Near cities it becomes market gardening. The grassland names are the classic matching set, so learn the grassland with its country.

Extensive commercial grain farming - grassland to country

Grassland	Country / region
Prairie	USA and Canada
Pampas	Argentina
Steppe	Russia and Ukraine
Veld	South Africa
Downs	Australia
Canterbury	New Zealand

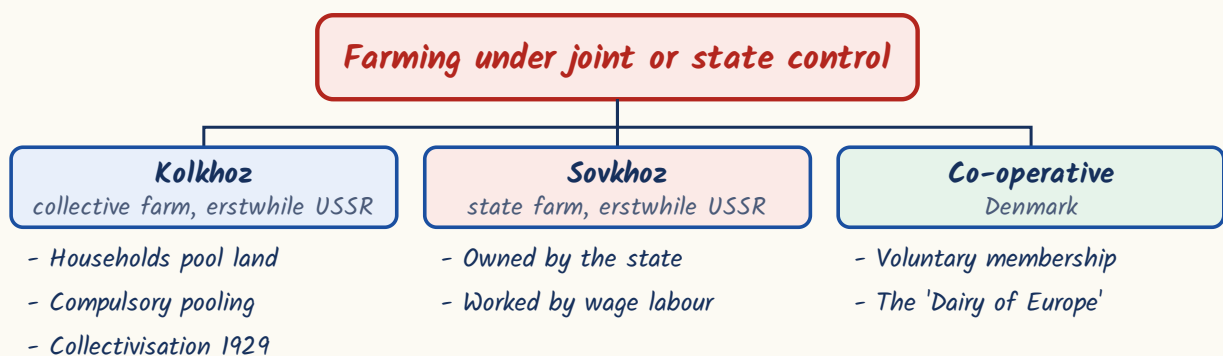
- Plantation agriculture was introduced in the tropics largely by European settlers.
- One cash crop, large estate, hired labour, heavy capital in processing and transport.
- Rubber - Malaysia; tea - Sri Lanka; coffee - Brazil; cocoa - Ghana; banana - Central America.
- It does NOT grow a variety of food crops for local consumption - that is the standard 'NOT a feature' option.

Plantation vs intensive subsistence

Plantation	Intensive subsistence
Tropics, colonial origin	Monsoon Asia, indigenous
Very large estates	Very small holdings
Hired wage labour	Family labour
Single cash crop for export	Food crops for the household
High capital, processing on site	Low capital, hand tools

- Commercial dairy farming is best developed in north-western Europe, north-eastern USA and New Zealand.
- Denmark is the classic case of co-operative farming - the 'Dairy of Europe'.
- New Zealand is the largest exporter of dairy products; India is the largest producer of milk.
- Market gardening or truck farming = intensive growing of vegetables, fruit and flowers close to big cities.
- 'Factory farming' = stall-fed livestock reared indoors on bought feed.
- Kolkhoz = the collective farm of the erstwhile USSR, run jointly by member households; collectivisation began in 1929.
- Sovkhoz = the state farm, owned by the state and worked by wage labour.
- Collective farming is compulsory pooling; co-operative farming (Denmark) is voluntary.

Collective, state and co-operative farms



Mediterranean agriculture – the RPSC repeat, learn it cold

This is the highest-value half page in the chapter. Mediterranean agriculture occurs only where the Mediterranean climate occurs – hot dry summers, mild wet winters – and that is exactly five belts in the world, all on the western side of continents between roughly 30 and 40 degrees latitude. RPSC asked it in 2024 and it asked it in the negative form: which region is NOT associated with Mediterranean agriculture. So you must know the five, and you must know the common wrong options.

The five Mediterranean agriculture belts

Belt	Continent / country
Mediterranean basin	Southern Europe, North Africa, the Levant
Central California	USA
Central Chile	South America
South-western Cape	South Africa
South-western and southern Australia	Australia

- Called the 'orchard lands of the world' – citrus, olives, figs, grapes.
- Viticulture, that is grape growing for wine, is their most distinctive commercial activity.
- Winter rain suits cereals; the long dry summer suits deep-rooted fruit trees and vines.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 – which region is NOT associated with the Mediterranean type of agriculture? The answer was the Pampas of Argentina. The Pampas is a temperate grassland of extensive grain farming and cattle ranching, not a Mediterranean belt.

ASKED IN RAS

Also asked in RAS Pre 2024 - Mediterranean agriculture is characteristically associated with the cultivation of citrus fruits, olives and grapes. Two questions from one topic in one paper. That is how narrow this section is.

TRAP

The trap options are always other famous farming regions - Pampas, Prairie, Steppe, Downs. All four are temperate grasslands, none of them is Mediterranean. Remember: Mediterranean belts sit on WEST coasts in the 30-40 degree band.

Crops and their leading producers

Learn producer and exporter separately, because RPSC's favourite trap is to swap them. A country can grow the most of something and still export almost none of it, because its own people eat it. India and milk is the obvious case. Stick to the stable leaders below - do not chase ranks that move a place or two every season.

Leading producers - food crops

Crop	No. 1 producer	No. 2
Rice	China	India
Wheat	China	India
Maize	USA	China
Soybean	Brazil	USA
Sugarcane	Brazil (about 40 per cent of world output)	India
Potato	China	India
Groundnut	China	India
Milk	India	-

Leading producers - beverage, industrial and tree crops

Crop	No. 1 producer	Point to remember
Coffee	Brazil	Vietnam No. 2 and the largest Robusta producer; coffee originated in the Ethiopian highlands
Tea	China	India No. 2, Kenya No. 3, Sri Lanka No. 4
Cocoa	Cote d'Ivoire	Ghana No. 2; both on the Gulf of Guinea coast
Natural rubber	Thailand	Indonesia No. 2, Vietnam No. 3; Hevea brasiliensis is native to the Amazon
Palm oil	Indonesia	With Malaysia No. 2, about 85 per cent of world output
Olives / olive oil	Spain	Italy No. 2
Jute	India	But Bangladesh is the largest exporter
Fish	China	Capture plus aquaculture, and largest exporter too

- Largest exporters: rice - India; wheat - Russia; maize - USA and Brazil; soybean - Brazil.
- Wool - Australia is the largest exporter.
- Dairy products - New Zealand is the largest exporter.
- Kenya is the largest exporter of black tea, though China and India produce far more.
- Cotton is the one big crop whose leading-producer rank keeps moving among China, India, Brazil and the USA - learn the group, not a No. 1.

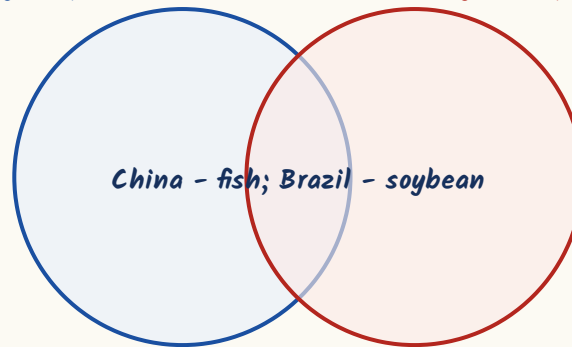
TRAP

Producer is not exporter. India produces the most milk and exports little. India produces the most jute but Bangladesh exports the most. China produces the most wheat but Russia exports the most. RPSC has built whole 'NOT correctly matched' questions on exactly this gap.

Largest producer and largest exporter

Largest producer

Largest exporter



∴ most jute, but New Zealand exports the most dairy and Bangladesh the most jute; China grows the most

ASKED IN RAS

Worth knowing what World Geography actually looked like in RAS Pre 2024 - only three questions, and two of them were pure matching: deserts to continents, Mediterranean agriculture regions, and tropical forests recording the highest deforestation. Read that as instruction: memorise pairs, do not read theory.

Fishing grounds, the revolutions, and FAO

The world's great fisheries sit where cold and warm waters meet, or where cold nutrient-rich water rises from below. That mixing brings up plankton and the fish follow. Two names come up again and again - the Grand Banks and the Peruvian anchoveta - so fix the location and the cause for each.

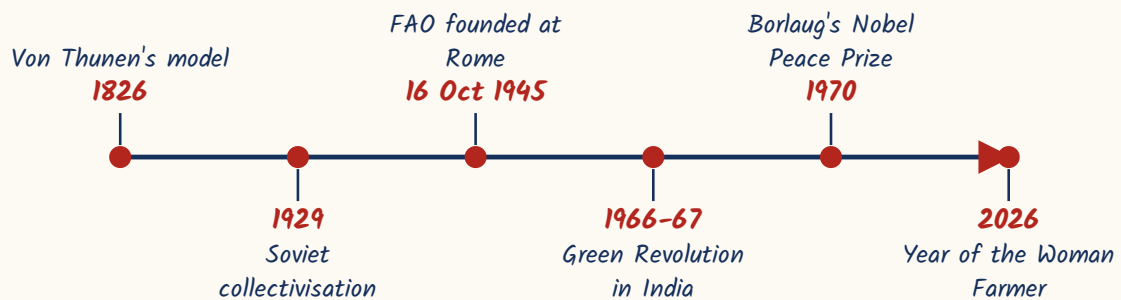
Major fishing grounds

Ground	Location	Why it is rich
North-West Pacific	Off Japan, Korea, eastern Russia	World's most productive fishing ground

Ground	Location	Why it is rich
North-East Atlantic	Off north-west Europe	Broad continental shelf
Grand Banks	Off Newfoundland, Canada	Labrador Current meets the Gulf Stream
Dogger Bank	North Sea	Shallow shelf bank
Georges Bank	Off New England, USA	Shelf and current mixing
Peru-Chile coast	West coast of South America	Upwelling of the Peru (Humboldt) Current

- The Peruvian anchoveta fishery depends on upwelling of cold, nutrient-rich water.
- In El Nino years the upwelling weakens and the catch collapses.
- China is the largest producer of fish - capture plus aquaculture - and the largest exporter of fishery products.
- Norman Borlaug - father of the Green Revolution, Nobel Peace Prize 1970, for dwarf high-yielding wheat.
- M. S. Swaminathan led the Indian adaptation of it from 1966-67.
- Colour revolutions: Green - foodgrains, White - milk, Blue - fish, Yellow - oilseeds, Golden - horticulture and honey.
- Pink - prawn and onion, Silver - eggs, Red - meat and tomato, Brown - leather and cocoa, Round - potato.
- White Revolution = Operation Flood, led by Verghese Kurien; it made India the largest milk producer.
- FAO was founded on 16 October 1945, headquarters Rome; World Food Day is 16 October.

Landmarks in world agriculture



CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: the FAO has designated 2026 the International Year of the Woman Farmer, launched to push gender equality in agrifood systems. RPSC likes UN 'International Year' designations in the current-affairs block - pair it with FAO's founding date, 16 October 1945, and World Food Day.

REVISION RECAP

1. Subsistence vs commercial - the only split that matters; everything else follows from it.
2. Von Thunen 1826: dairy and market gardening innermost, ranching outermost.
3. Shifting cultivation names: Jhum-NE India, Milpa-Mexico, Ladang-Indonesia, Chena-Sri Lanka, Roca-Brazil, Taungya-Myanmar.
4. Herders: Bedouin-camel, Masai-cattle, Lapps and Chukchi-reindeer, Fulani-West Africa.
5. Transhumance is seasonal highland-lowland movement, not nomadism; Gujjar-Bakarwal is the Indian example.
6. Grain grasslands: Prairie-USA/Canada, Pampas-Argentina, Steppe-Russia/Ukraine, Veld-South Africa, Downs-Australia, Canterbury-New Zealand.
7. Plantation = one cash crop, big estate, hired labour, European origin in the tropics.
8. Kolkhoz collective, Sovkhoz state farm, Denmark co-operative.
9. Mediterranean agriculture = five belts only: Med. basin, central California, central Chile, SW Cape, SW/southern Australia. Citrus, olives, grapes; viticulture is the signature.
10. Rice, wheat, tea, potato, groundnut, fish - China No. 1. Maize - USA. Soybean, sugarcane, coffee - Brazil.

11. Cocoa - Cote d'Ivoire; rubber - Thailand; palm oil - Indonesia; olives - Spain; milk and jute - India.
12. Exporters: rice-India, wheat-Russia, dairy-New Zealand, wool-Australia, jute-Bangladesh, black tea-Kenya.
13. Grand Banks off Newfoundland - Labrador Current meets Gulf Stream. NW Pacific is the most productive ground.
14. Peru anchoveta lives on upwelling; El Nino kills the catch.
15. Borlaug - Green Revolution, Nobel Peace 1970. FAO 16 October 1945, Rome. 2026 is the International Year of the Woman Farmer.